Chapter 37

The Gandhian Way:
If I Were the Police Commissioner …

'Sir, why are you moving me to the Bureau of Police Research and Development when I am preparing Delhi for citizen policing?' This was the question I asked Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil during one of my call-on meetings with him at his New Delhi residence.

I added: *'Sir, the current police commissioner (Delhi) has already overshot his tenure and would go sooner or later. Why don't you let me be here* [I was DG Home Guards and Civil Defence] *and continue to prepare my planned target of over a hundred thousand youth in the Civil Defence and Home Guards to become a strong ally of the Delhi Police?'*

The minister just kept quiet.

I persisted:

'I will bring in police reforms and have them in place in three months' time. They will bring you credit. Delhi could then become a model city of metropolitan policing.'

The minister finally spoke up:

'I don't decide who will be the next police commissioner.'

I was a bit surprised at the reply, but, nevertheless, continued:

'Sir, but you are the home minister. And if you cannot decide then my case rests here. But in case I am overlooked I will move on sir.'

He did not say anything.

I then left his room and made my way out. Imagine my surprise when, at the minister's residence itself, there were a few who walked up to me and said they were waiting to see me posted as the police commissioner. And out of keenness to see that I did occupy that top post, they told me: 'Madam why don't you please see Mrs G [meaning Mrs Sonia Gandhi, the president of the Congress Party and the chairperson of the United Progressive Alliance Government at the Centre]. Our minister is very weak. He will not take any decision on his own.'

I then told them that I would not go to any political office for seeking a posting.

However, all kinds of rumours were afloat, especially of my likely meeting with Mrs G or even my having met her. This is because some persons really wanted to see me calling on her (to join the club of servile sycophants) on bent knees and with folded hands.

But, most interestingly, while I was neither calling on nor approaching any person in political power to intervene, I was sounded out to consider a request by the emissary of a particular political party to stand for an election to Parliament. I responded instantly by sending a polite sms expressing gratitude for considering me and that I was only waiting for the decision on the new police commissioner to be finalized and nothing else.

While I kept my word and stuck to my belief, events took place exactly as per my intuition. I was